

that the games might be better looking on Sega's console but the games and gameplay were just so much more fun on the Gameboy. Sure the games looked worse but when you have franchises such as Mario, Metroid, Zelda and more, you're already a step ahead of the competition. As a kid, you don't think about the price our parents paid for our luxuries so I never understood why the Gameboy was doing so much better. It should have been clear that the Game Gear was priced at \$150 at retail while the Gameboy was a measly \$90. Back in the day, even \$50 was a lot of money and with waning support from third-party games and Nintendo signing exclusive developer rights, the road was already a tough one for the Game Gear. Eventually, the console was relegated to a dark corner of my cupboard while the Gameboy was my go-to gaming device.

This carried on for a couple of years until the debut of the Gameboy Advance in 2001. Sure, Nintendo had the Gameboy Mini and the Colour but none were as substantial a jump in terms of graphics and gameplay as the Advance. Again, as far as the games go, Nintendo delivered hit after hit. We got Metroid Fusion, Castlevania: Aria of Sorrow, Mario and Luigi: Superstar Saga and many more. This time we got a full 32-bit system jammed into an ergonomic handheld device. The Advance was leap and bounds ahead of its predecessor in that it completely skipped the 16-bit era. The graphics looked much better and this reflected in more gameplay depth. Although games like the Mortal Kombat port on the Advance looked bad and it was practically unplayable. For every 10 awesome games Nintendo released, we always got a dud or two thrown in for good measure. The Gameboy Advance was my go-to sys-

tem for about 5 years until the Sony PSP came along and showed me what a powerful handheld device was actually capable of.

Note: You'll have to forgive me but I hated and still hate Pokemon and will never touch any game from the franchise, so those looking for a nostalgia trip down Pokemon world will be severely disappointed. I don't have the slightest idea of what the franchise is about and I prefer it that way.

When Sony launched the PlayStation in 1995, it was the new hotness. With 32-bit graphics, 3D gaming, more complex storylines and mechanics, the PS One firmly entrenched Sony in the world of console gaming and it's been a hell of a ride since then. I owned a PS One and subsequently moved on



to the PS2 sometime in 2004. And although I'd still whip out my Gameboy Advanced SP from time to time for a quick game of Mario Kart: Super Circuit or my annual playthrough of Metroid Fusion, my SP joined its elder brother and the Game Gear in the back of a dusty cupboard. I was, after all, now in love with the DVD-playing, God of War running machine, the mighty PS2. For a while there, it seemed like I was finally getting over my handheld obsession. That was until the debut of the PSP in 2005. Again, I was incredibly lucky to have a cousin of mine purchase it from Austria and personally deliver it to me. Opening up that box is a feeling that cannot be replicated. I mean it's why so many unboxing channels

exist on Youtube, right? My cousin bought me the white version of the console and it looked magnificent. The only real issue was the fact that there were no official games launched here so sail the high seas, I did. I managed to crack my PSP and I still feel bad about it but what can one do when you're broke and still want to game? I remember spending hours perfecting the combat system on UFC Undisputed in 2010 and even using the PSP as the ultimate PS One emulation machine. The PlayStation Portable wasn't the incredible seller that the Gameboy was but it paved the way for future handheld systems. It was powerful, easy to use and had an amazing game library. The fact that it could also be used as an emulation machine also added to the console's legacy.

On the side though, I managed to snag a sweet Nintendo DS from one of my younger cousins and for a gimmicky system, it had a few games that were worth it. The Legend of Zelda: Phantom Hourglass really made use of the system and I actually found myself incredibly engrossed in the Zelda franchise. I did not spend as much time as I should have on the DS but I game a ton on the DS' successor, The Nintendo 3DS.

The PSP remained my daily gaming platform when I moved away from home in 2008. I had just started working for a music magazine and didn't have the cash for video games. The PSP served me incredibly well during the first few years of living alone. It wasn't until I got the Nintendo 3DS XL for my 32nd birthday. The console came packaged with Mario and Luigi: Dream Team and I also received Super Mario 3D Land as a bonus. I must have sunk in at least 300 or more hours into both games. The 3DS XL became my go-to gaming console. Games like Resident Evil Revelations, Ultra Street Fighter